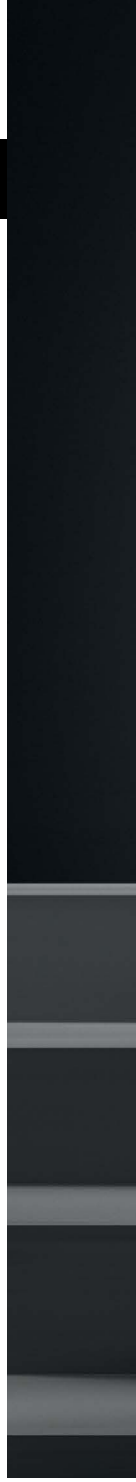
▶ **S. JAISHANKAR**
Union Minister of External Affairs

"WE NEED TO BE PATIENT AND PERSEVERING"

External affairs minister S. Jaishankar has been guiding India's diplomacy through the thickets of geopolitcs: contentious themes like Ukraine and Gaza which demanded that a side be chosen, and insecure shipping lanes in the Red Sea. But the most pressing one is the continuing stand-off with China along the Line of Actual Control (LAC). In a frank conversation during the India Today Conclave, the former diplomat said that with the forward deployment of the armed forces of both countries, de-escalation assumes huge importance. "We have to be both patient and persevering with it," he added. Jaishankar emphasised the need for India to fortify its domestic sector to effectively counter the challenges posed by China: "If you are dealing with China, you got to have an economy that is geared up for it. We have it now." He also touched upon the role India is playing in the ongoing global conflicts. When asked about reports that Prime Minister Narendra Modi helped avert a nuclear attack on Ukraine by Russia, Jaishankar said, "We have been continuously doing whatever we can to reduce tensions, to relieve worries, to see things don't happen which make it worse." The Indian Navy, he said, has been providing maritime security in the troubled waters of West Asia. "We have about 12 ships in and around the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden and Red Sea. It is one of the largest deployments in terms of national commitment," he said.

On biases and falsehoods spread on social media, including by foreign elements, Jaishankar said that nobody can fix social media due to its nature. However, he acknowledges that Indian diplomacy was now adept at "short, sharp, impactful expressions" that bust false narratives.

Speaking on the controversy over the killing of Khalistani operative Hardeep Singh Nijjar (in Canada) and the alleged conspiracy to kill US national and Khalistani terrorist Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, Jaishankar differentiated between Canada and the US, which "has not given the same kind of space to violent extremist views and activities that Canada has done". Indeed, India decided to set up a "high-powered committee" to look into the charges, as there seemed to be an "organised crime aspect" to the case after the US shared information. Jaishankar also deplored Western concerns about the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, when most of them had a warped or nil understanding of history underlying the legislation. ■



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

"I AM PAID TO FIX FOREIGN POLICY, NOT SOCIAL MEDIA. NO ONE CAN FIX IT. BUT WE HAVE ADJUSTED TO THE REALITY. IT'S A MEDIUM WHERE SHORT, SHARP IMPACTFUL EXPRESSIONS ARE REQUIRED"

"IF YOU WANT TO DEAL WITH CHINA, YOU NEED TO HAVE AN ECONOMY THAT IS GEARED UP FOR IT. WE HAVE THAT NOW, BUT ONLY IN THE PAST DECADE"